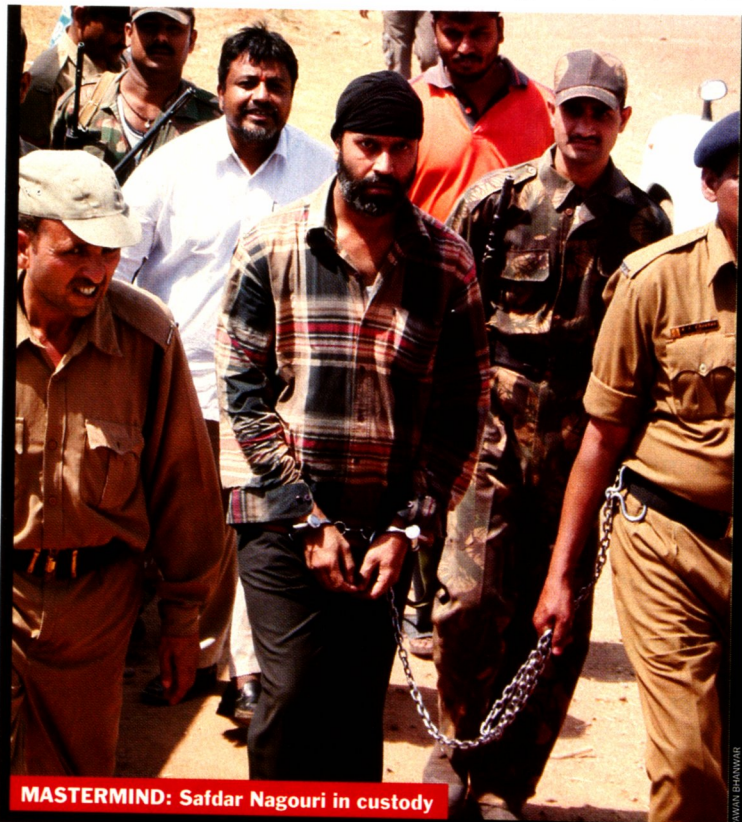


THE NAGOURI 13



MASTERMIND: Safdar Nagouri in custody

The arrest of a gang led by Safdar Nagouri



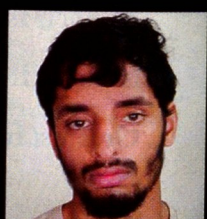
Ahmad Beg



Ansaar



Kamraan



Kamaruddin Nagouri

■ By Ambreesh Mishra

Terrorists as portrayed in movies or the grainy shots of training camps follow a stereotype: heavily bearded, intense, hooded eyes and the demeanour of a remorseless killer. In real life, it is seldom the same. So it is with Safdar Nagouri, 38, the terror mastermind who was arrested along with 12 others in a pre-dawn swoop in Indore last week. He is a pious-looking young man with the air of a timid religious scholar, not the cold-blooded mass murderer that police say he is. In fact, shortly after his capture, he politely requested his captors to allow him to offer his early morning namaaz. In reality, it is the prayers of anti-terrorist forces that seem to have been answered. Nagouri and his group,

by all accounts, represent the most important catch ever of a terror mastermind outside of J&K.

Nagouri is a former general secretary of the outlawed Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI), and he and his cohorts are, according to the Special Task Force which has been tracking them, responsible for setting off bombs and killing innocent people in numerous terror strikes across the country since 2001, including the Mumbai serial train blasts in 2006 which killed nearly 200 innocent commuters and injured 1,000 others. Central security agencies and police forces from at least half a dozen states which have been involved in investigations, say the Nagouri 13, as they are being called, are—unlike Kashmiri insurgents or the ISI-fuelled terror ventures of the D-

Company that were localised—increasingly pan-Indian. Their deadly network is also entirely home-grown, well-educated, highly motivated and radicalised beyond redemption.

Although interrogators are tight-lipped about the grilling over the last week, they concede that targetting top BJP leaders like L.K. Advani, Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi and others for the Babri and Gujarat episodes was only a short-term shock tactic. The grand vision of the breakaway SIMI faction was much broader: to establish *Ummah* and convert all of India into the land of the faithful. That may have been a quest for a fool's paradise but that they could have created widespread havoc is unquestionable. The dossier of their deadly deeds is already thick. Nagouri's name has figured in the statement of